

User Interaction and Usability of Digital Products
+
Human-Computer Interaction
CLASS-16

Navigation Models...

Navigation Models...What is the navigational model for your site or app?

How do the different screens (or pages, or spaces) link to each other, and how do users move between them?

Global navigation is what's found on every main screen. It usually takes the form of menus, tabs, and/or sidebars, and this is how users move around the formal navigational structure of the site.

Utility navigation, also found on every main screen, contains links and tools related to non-content aspects of the site or application: sign-in, help, print, language tools, and so on.

Associative and inline navigation embed links in or near the actual content. As the user reads or interacts with the site, these links present options that might be immediately relevant to the user. They tie content together thematically

Navigation Models... few models found in typical sites and apps

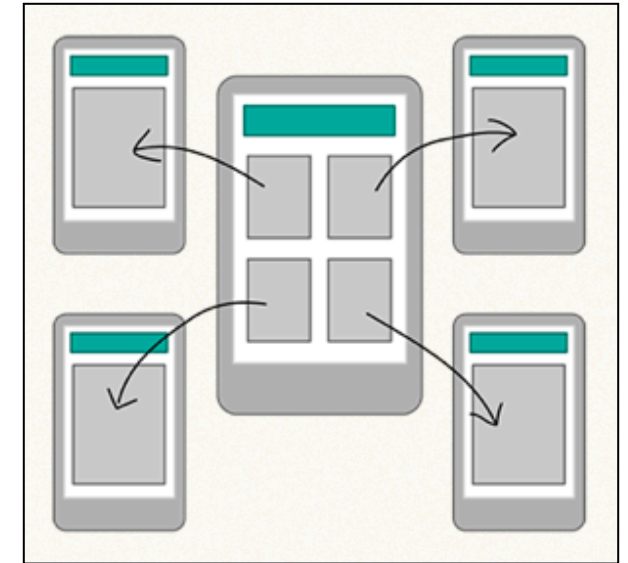
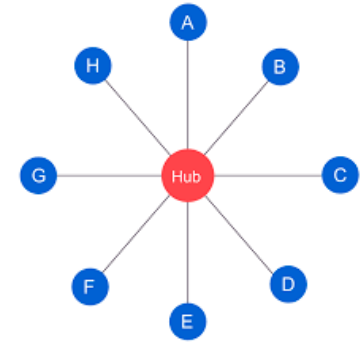
Hub and Spoke Model

Most often found on mobile devices, this architecture lists all the major parts of the site or app on the home screen, or “hub.”

The user clicks or taps through to them, does what she needs to do, and comes back to the hub to go somewhere else.

The “spoke” screens focus tightly on their jobs, making careful use of space—they may not have room to list all the other major screens.

The iPhone home screen is a good example; the Menu Page pattern found on some websites is another.



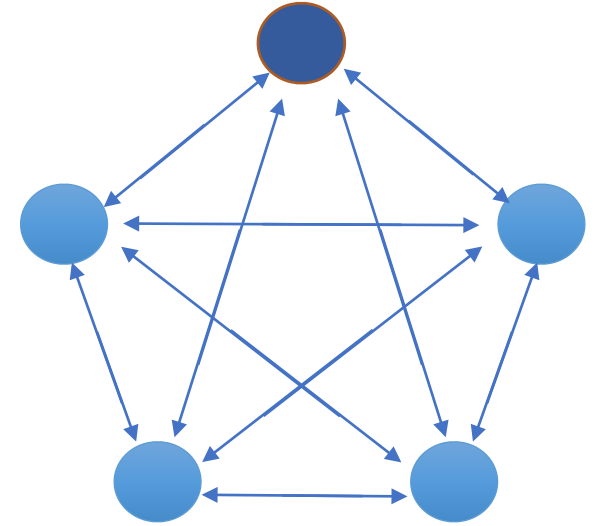
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Fully Connected

Many websites follow this model.

There's a home page or screen, but it and every other page link to all the others—they each have a global navigation feature, such as a top menu.

The global navigation may be a single level, or it might be deep and complex, with multiple levels and deeply buried content. As long as the user can reach any page from any other with a single jump, it's fully connected.



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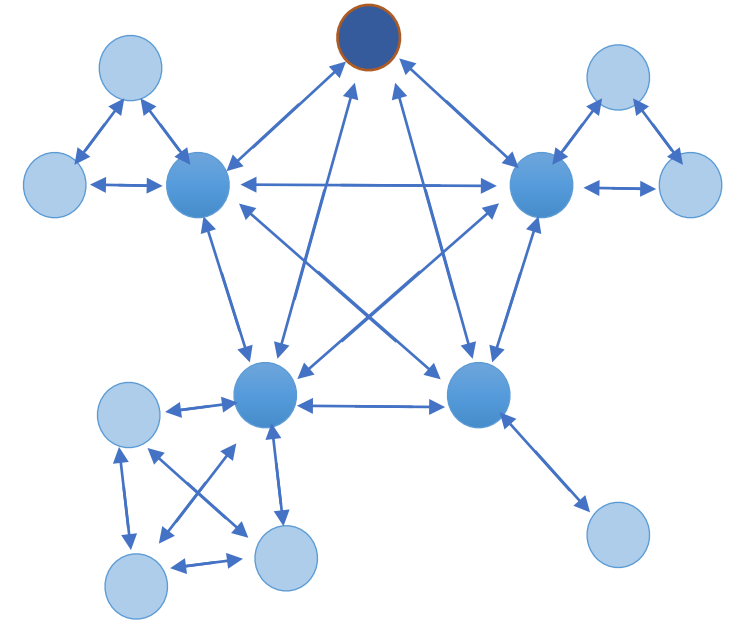
Multi Levels

This is also common among websites.

The main pages are fully connected with each other, but the subpages are only connected among themselves (and usually to the other main pages, via global navigation).

This is seen on sites that have subpages listed only in sidebars or sub tabs—users see these on menus that only show up after they've clicked the link for the main page or category. It takes two or more jumps to get from one arbitrary subpage to another.

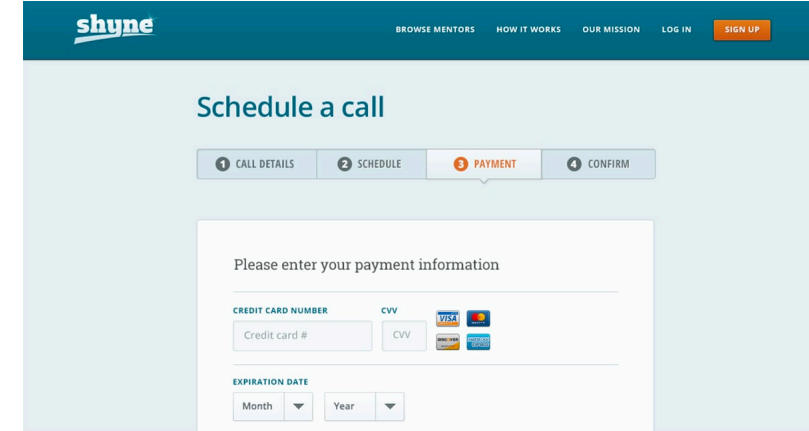
Using drop-down menus, the Fat Menu pattern, or the Sitemap Footer pattern with a multi-level site converts it to a fully connected one, which is preferable



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Stepwise

Slideshows, process flows, and Wizards lead the user step by step through the screens in a prescribed sequence. Back/Next links are prominent on the page.

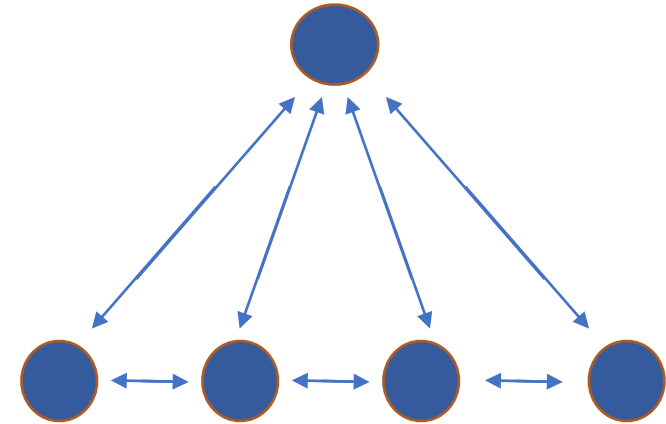


Pyramid

A variant on the stepwise model, a pyramid uses a hub page or menu page to list an entire sequence of items or subpages in one place.

The user picks out any item, jumps to it, and then has the option to use Back/Next links to step through other items in order.

The User can go back to the hub page anytime. See the Pyramid pattern in this chapter for more.

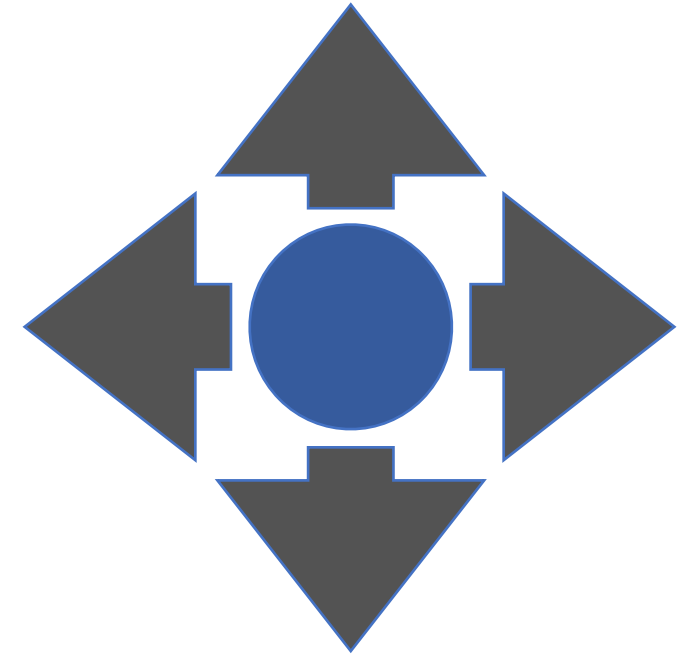


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Pan-and-Zoom

Some artefacts are best represented as single large spaces, not many small ones. Maps, large images, large text documents, information graphics, and representations of time based media (such as sound and video) fall into this category.

Panning and zooming are still navigation—so offer controls for panning (moving horizontally or vertically), zooming in and out, and resetting to a known position and state.

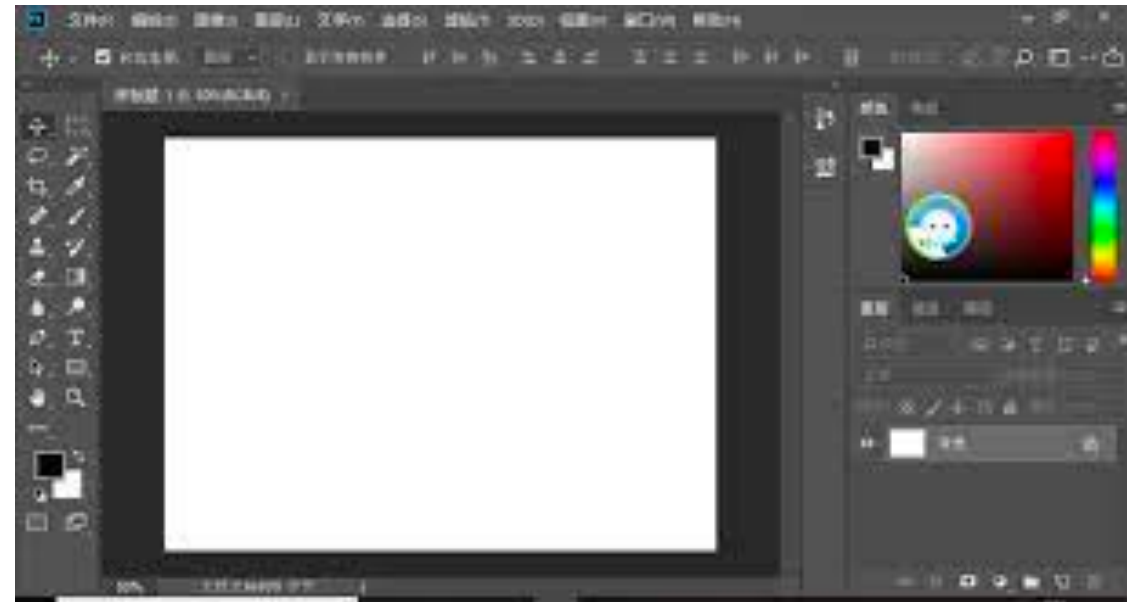


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Flat Navigation

Some types of applications need little or no navigation at all. Consider Canvas Plus Palette applications such as Photoshop, or other complex apps such as Excel—these offer tons of tools and functions that are easily reached via menus, toolbars, and palettes.

Tools that don't act immediately upon the work may be accessible via Modal Panels or step-by-step progressions. These types of applications seem to be qualitatively different from the other navigation styles listed here: the user always knows where he is, but he may not easily find the tools he needs because of the sheer number of features available at one time.

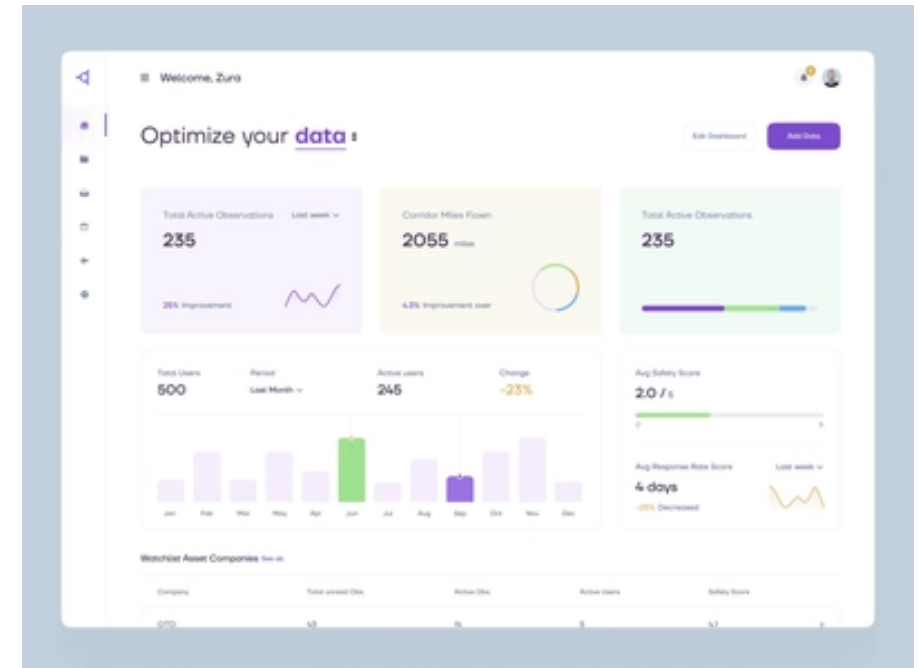
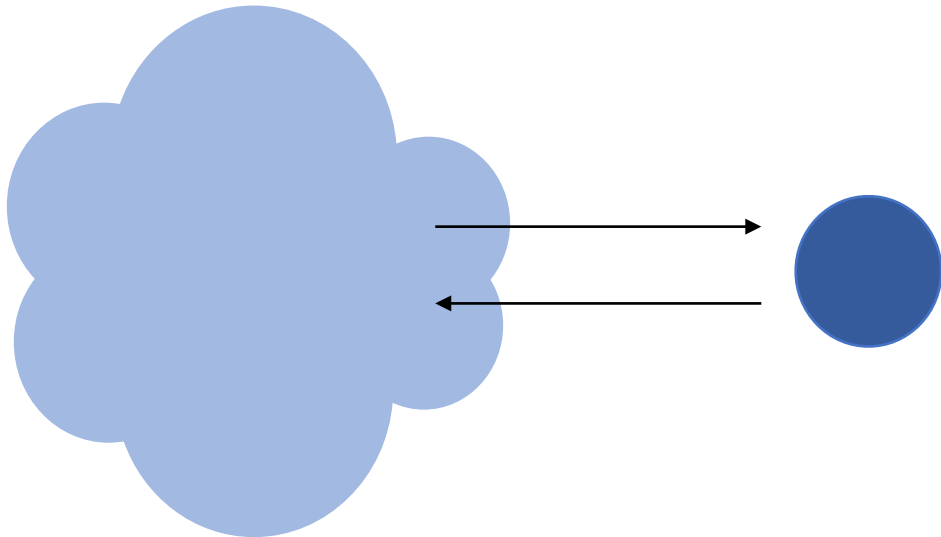


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Model Panel

This brings a user to a screen with no navigation options other than acknowledging its message, completing its form, or clicking the panel away.

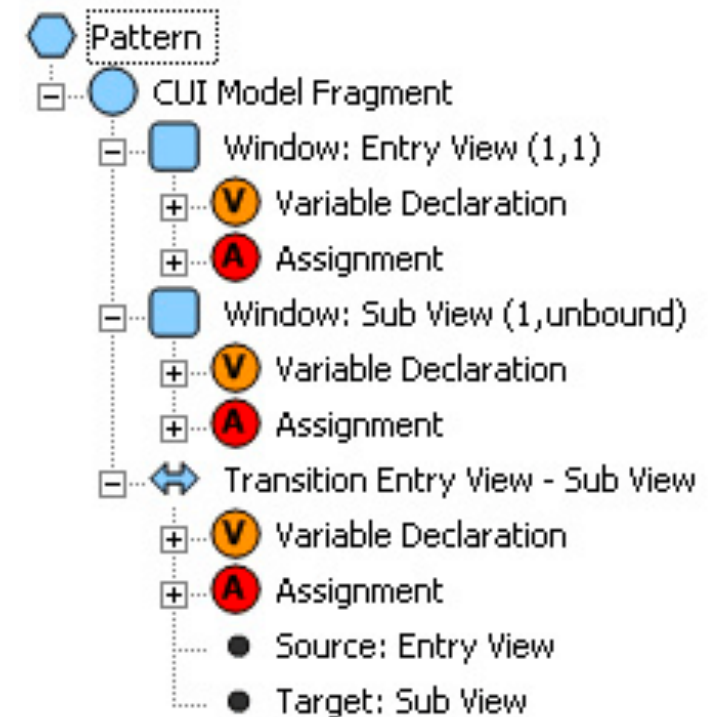
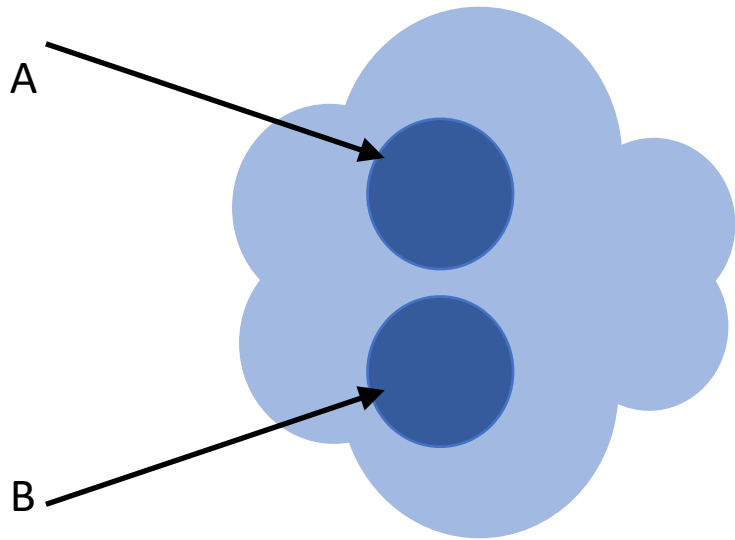
Modal panels often show up layered on top of a full screen or page, and are used for small, focused tasks that require the user's full attention. Example: Dashboard



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Clear Entry Points

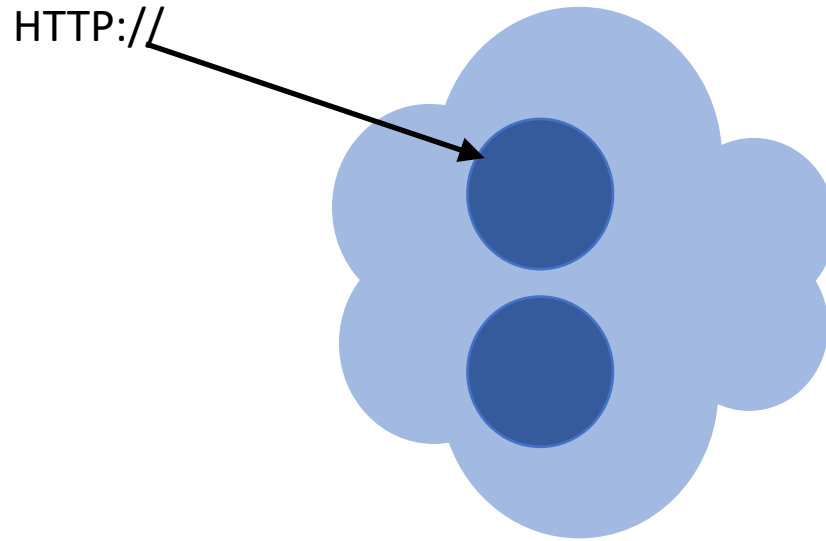
Clear entry points How does a user know where to start in a complex site or app? The Clear Entry Points pattern shows him where to go first. For first-time and infrequent users, it removes some of the burden of learning the site.



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Bookmarks

Bookmarks , permalinks, deep links, and Deep-linked State are all ways for a user to conveniently navigate to a point of his choice, anytime he wants, even if it's deep inside a navigational structure. These give him a way to avoid traversing many links to get to a desired page or state.



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Escape Hatch

When a user is hopelessly entangled in an app, reaches an error state, or gets deep linked into a page that he has no context for understanding, he needs an escape hatch, a well-labeled link to get back to a known place.

